

9 Communicating Sexually: The Closest Physical Encounter

Although Brittany, Sarah, and Taylor are sorority sisters, their sex lives could not be more different. Brittany has been seeing the same man for 4 years and has an active sex life. She believes her boyfriend, Chris, is completely faithful, but she insisted they both get tested to be sure they do not have sexually transmitted infections (STIs). She is on the pill and tries to be as responsible about sex as possible, yet she has never discussed her active sex life with her parents. Though she loves Chris, she is not entirely sure he is the “one” for her. Sarah is deeply religious and has chosen to remain a virgin until after marriage. Sometimes she feels strange because most of the girls in the house are not virgins. She enjoys sexual activity with her boyfriend but always makes sure that they stop well short of sexual intercourse. Occasionally, her sisters are unkind and call Sarah frigid or prudish, which makes Sarah feel that her values are out of the mainstream. Taylor dated men but recently admitted to herself and the world that she has always been more attracted to women. She announced to her sisters that she is a lesbian and is in a committed, monogamous relationship with her partner, Leslie. Most of the women in the house accepted her fully; however, she has heard a few homophobic comments and caught some of her sisters exchanging strange glances when she mentions Leslie.

Sex is one of the most rewarding and difficult issues people face. In this chapter, we focus on sexual behavior and its importance in human relationships. Also, we examine communication related to the development of sexual attitudes and beliefs, initiation and refusal of sexual activity, coercion and harassment, and safe sex in short- and long-term relationships. The research clearly demonstrates that communication is essential for healthy sexual relationships and sexual satisfaction. Many close relationships are platonic, but some of our closest encounters are sexual, including romances and marriages. Most studies focus on sexual relationships between men and women; however, we make an effort to include the existing research about relationships between gay men, lesbians, and bisexuals. Also, most studies focus on attitudes and behaviors of U.S. couples; in other countries, sexual attitudes and behaviors may be quite different. Finally, the physiology of sex and sexual desire is beyond the scope of this chapter, although excellent books on these topics are available (see Regan & Berscheid, 1999).

Sex in Relationships

Research shows that sexual interaction, including intimate kissing, touching, and sexual intercourse, is a vital part of dating and marital relationships. Although people experience some ambivalence about sex in premarital relationships (O'Sullivan & Gaines, 1998), sexual involvement is typical in most dating relationships (Twenge, Sherman, & Wells, 2015). For most people, sex, attraction, desire, romance, and love are closely intertwined. Differences in sexual interaction often exist based on the type of relationship people share, including short-term versus long-term and gay versus straight. Men and women also differ in their sexual attitudes and behaviors.

Sex in Short-Term and Early Dating Relationships

Short-term sex occurs when a couple has sex without having an emotionally close relationship. Most short-term sex takes the form of hook-ups or one-night stands. **Hook-ups** are spontaneous, casual sexual encounters with an acquaintance or a stranger who is not a regular dating partner with no expectations of a long-term relationship, although not all hook-ups culminate in sexual intercourse (Bogle, 2008; Heldman & Wade, 2010; Mongeau & Wiedmaier, 2011). Hook-ups are intended as one-night stands but may become more enduring relationships. Since the turn of the century, hook-ups have become an increasingly common form of relational and sexual interaction engaged in by a majority of college students. Contrary to the stereotype that only men seek short-term sexual relationships, research shows that women also engage in short-term mating strategies for many of the same reasons as men: sexual desire, sexual experimentation, physical pleasure, and alcohol or drug use (Buunk, Dijkstra, Fetchenhauer, & Kenrick, 2002; Reid, Elliott, & Webber, 2011). Because hook-ups are often motivated primarily by sexual desire, they are not likely to transform into serious romantic relationships (Jonason, 2012).

Recent research has suggested that dating is not dead; it is still common on college campuses and considered to be a higher quality relationship than a hook-up. Thirty percent of students describe themselves as in a committed dating relationship (Mongeau & Wiedmaier, 2011). Research has generally shown that women are less positive and more negative about hook-ups than men (Campbell, 2008; Heldman & Wade, 2010; Mongeau & Wiedmaier, 2011), although both women and men are more positive than negative (Owen & Fincham, 2011). One study suggests that hook-ups do often lead to a date and that in the hook-up scenario women have considerable agency and control over the situation and its consequences (Reid et al., 2011). However, the sexual script and sexual practices are more ambiguous in hook-ups, particularly for women, and the types of sex that are engaged are often difficult negotiations (Backstrom, Armstrong, & Puentes, 2012).

Although hook-ups and one-night stands are increasingly common, premarital sex typically occurs in dating relationships between people who share some relational and emotional intimacy. In these relationships, people seek to experience sexual attraction, sexual arousal, and relational closeness (Mongeau et al., 2004; O'Sullivan & Gaines, 1998). Research suggests that first sex is a turning point in relationships for better or worse (Metts, 2004; Reissing, Anduff, & Wentland, 2012). Both men and women experience a variety of positive and negative emotions in early sexual encounters, but females are more likely than males to experience negative

emotions such as sadness, guilt, or embarrassment whereas males are more likely to experience more anxiety but also more positive emotions such as pleasure, happiness, pride, and excitement (Cupach, Metts, & Hoffman, 2012; Sprecher, 2014). Situational factors, such as drinking alcohol, can also prompt sexual involvement in both hook-ups and long-term relationships (Heldman & Wade, 2010; Klein, Geaghan, & MacDonald, 2007; Morr & Mongeau, 2004; Sprecher & McKinney, 1993) as can special occasions such as prom or anniversaries. In the eyes of both men and women, alcohol consumption by women increased dating intimacy, but alcohol use by men decreased dating intimacy (Ip & Heubeck, 2016).

In the past two decades **friends with benefits** have become more prevalent (see also [Chapter 10](#)). These are sexual but nonromantic relationships among friends or acquaintances. About a quarter of all college students have had a “friends-with-benefits” relationship, and they are equally prevalent among urban and rural high school and college students (Eisenberg, Ackard, Resnick, & Neumark-Sztainer, 2009; Letcher & Carmona, 2015). There are numerous subtypes of these relationships including “true” friends who have sex, serial hook-ups, and various types of transitions in and out of relationships (Knight, Wiedmaier, Mongeau, Eden, & Roberto, 2012; Mongeau, Knight, Williams, Eden, & Shaw, 2013) but true friends, defined as close friends having sex are the most common. (See [Chapter 10](#) for a more detailed discussion of the different types of friends-with-benefits relationships.) There is little risk of harmful psychological outcomes in friends-with-benefits relationships (Eisenberg et al., 2009) and most people in friends-with-benefits relationships have sexually permissive attitudes (Akbulut & Weger, 2016). Some of these relationships transition from friends with benefits to a conventional romantic relationship (VanderDrift, Lehmiller, & Kelly, 2012). However, most friends-with-benefits relationships are placeholders until a more serious romantic relationship comes along (Jonason, 2012).

Sex in Long-Term Relationships

Criteria for long-term romantic partners differ from those for a first date or a short-term sexual encounter. In long-term relationships, both men and women place a high value on qualities such as interpersonal skill, emotional stability, responsiveness, affection, and family orientation, and less value on physical attraction (Buunk et al., 2002). Women throughout the world prefer long-term partners higher in social and economic status than themselves (Buunk et al., 2002; Fales et al., 2016). But sex itself is important; in long-term relationships, “sexual desire is a distinguishing feature and a prerequisite of the romantic love experience” (Regan & Berscheid, 1999, p. 126). In short-term sexual encounters, by contrast, sexual desire is often present without love or intimacy, though even in short-term sexual encounters intimacy is positively correlated with sexual satisfaction (Birnie-Porter & Hunt, 2015).

The most satisfying sex takes place in long-term romantic relationships, not in hook-ups or short-term dating relationships (DeLamater & Hyde, 2004; Heldman & Wade, 2010; Willetts, Sprecher, & Beck, 2004). Married people have higher levels of sexual satisfaction than dating or cohabiting couples (Sprecher & Cate, 2004), although engaged couples have the highest level of sexual satisfaction (Birnie-Porter & Hunt, 2015). Sexual intimacy evolved to keep mates interested in one another (Buss, 1988b; Hendrick & Hendrick, 2002). A couple’s ongoing sexual interest promotes bonding, cooperation, and a stable environment for childrearing

(Buss, 1994; Sprecher & Cate, 2004). Sex is best when it is motivated by wanting to feel good about oneself, please one's partner, or promote intimacy. Sex is not as pleasurable or relationship enhancing when prompted by motives such as preventing one's partner from getting upset, avoiding conflict, or preventing one's partner from losing interest (Impett, Peplau, & Gable, 2005).

Although men's sexual desire peaks in their early 20s and women's in their 30s, the association between relational and sexual satisfaction is high throughout life, even for seniors (Howard, O'Neill, & Travers, 2006; Taylor & Gosney, 2011). The amount of sex declines as couples age, but sexual satisfaction does not (DeLamater & Hyde, 2004, Howard et al., 2006; Willetts et al., 2004). Research shows that as women age into midlife and the senior years, feeling attractive is associated with sexual desire, enjoyment, frequency of sexual activity, and ability to reach orgasm (Koch, Mansfield, Thuraau, & Carey, 2005).

Both men and women view sexual desire and satisfaction as vital to true romantic love (Holmberg, Blair, & Phillips, 2010; Regan, 1998; Regan & Berscheid, 1999; Sprecher & Cate, 2004) with physical contact—including touching, kissing, and sexual intercourse—seen as an essential part of expressing that love (Christopher & Kissler, 2004; Regan & Berscheid, 1999). People with high levels of sexual desire in their relationships report higher levels of excitement, connection, love, and relational satisfaction (Byers, Demmons, & Lawrence, 1998; Christopher & Kissler, 2004; Hendrick & Hendrick, 2002; Sprecher & Regan, 1996). Interestingly, the positive association between sexual satisfaction and relational satisfaction also exists in China, suggesting the cross-cultural strength of this association (Reined, Byers, & Pan, 1997). If the relationship is satisfying and if neither partner feels coerced or obligated to have sex, their first experience of sexual intercourse usually has a positive effect on the relationship (Cate, Long, Angera, & Draper, 1993). This is not to say that sex always makes a relationship better, but high-quality sex can contribute to a good relationship. Of course, many other factors also contribute to relational satisfaction, such as commitment, love, and compatibility. Recent research shows that teens experience more relational and sexual satisfaction when they meet face to face rather than online, and when they know the partner better before having sex (Blunt-Vinti, Wheldon, McFarlane, Brogan, & Walsh-Buhi, 2016), suggesting that traditional romantic dating patterns still lead to the best outcomes.

Sex Differences

Sex is an important part of a good relationship, but men and women are not identical in their sexual inclinations and behaviors. Biologically, women invest more time and resources in becoming a parent. For women, reproduction involves finding a mate, having sex, going through pregnancy and childbirth, nursing and nurturing the baby, and in most cases raising the child to adulthood; for men, only finding a mate and having sex are biological imperatives (Trost & Alberts, 2006). This may be why women are much choosier than men about who to have a one-night stand with. For many men, the ideal short-term mate is physically attractive (Buunk et al., 2002; Fales et al., 2016; Greitemeyer, 2005; Van Straaten, Engels, Finkenauer, & Holland, 2008), but men are willing to compromise on traits such as intelligence and status. For women, the ideal short-term partner is physically attractive, somewhat older, more experienced, self-confident, intelligent, interpersonally responsive, and has a steady income, (Buunk et al., 2002; Fales et al., 2016; Trost & Alberts,

2006).

Men and women also differ in terms of sexual desire and sexual attraction. Studies consistently show that men have a stronger sex drive than women (DeLamater & Hyde, 2004; Holmberg & Blair, 2009; Vohs, Catanese, & Baumeister, 2004) and that they experience greater sexual arousal in response to a short-term sexual opportunity than women do (Stone, Shackelford, & Goetz, 2011). Among first-year college students, men had an equal amount of reward from either oral or vaginal sex while women found vaginal sex more rewarding (Lefkowitz, Vasilenko, & Levitt, 2016). For men, sexy looks, erotic situations, and friendly social behaviors promote sexual desire (Benuto & Meana, 2008; Buunk et al., 2002; Cupach & Metts, 1995; Greitemeyer, 2005; Regan, 2004). Women, in contrast, are sexually attracted to men who are relationally oriented, emotionally connected, and who show tenderness and intimacy with them. Indeed, studies show that women's sexual desire is more dependent on feelings, the type of relationship they share with the partner, the potential for intimacy and humor, and the status and intelligence of the man (McCall & Meston, 2006), whereas men's desire is more influenced by physical attraction, sexual pleasure, and erotic qualities (Buunk et al., 2002; Greitemeyer, 2005; Metts, 2004; Regan, 2004; Regan & Berscheid, 1995, 1999).

Box 9.1 Tech Talk: Cybersexuality

Online sexual interaction has become increasingly common. In 2012, the Internet Filter Learning Center reported that about 12% of all Internet content contained pornography, and that 40 million people in the United States view Internet pornography on a regular basis, of which 72% are male. And the United States is not alone. According to the Internet Filter Learning Center, every second 28,258 Internet users around the world view pornography. An analysis by country of searches using the words *porn* and *XXX* revealed that the United States was not even in the top 10. The most searches with the keyword *porn* were in South Africa, Ireland, and New Zealand. The most searches for *XXX* were in Bolivia, Chile, and Romania. Another study (Twohig, Crosby, & Cox, 2009) revealed that around half of the college-aged men they surveyed (compared to less than 3% of the college-aged women they surveyed) reported viewing Internet pornography at least once in the past 3 months.

Some people think Internet pornography has contributed to a degeneration of morals, a deterioration of personal relationships, and can lead to Internet sexual addiction (Griffiths, 2012). One recent study showed that pornography consumption was related to flirting with others and being less committed to one's partner and less commitment was related to infidelity (Lambert, Negash, Stillman, Olmstead, & Fincham, 2012). Other people think such sites are a form of safe sex that prevents STIs and unwanted pregnancies. Twohig and others' (2009) research suggests that viewing Internet pornography is problematic for some people but not others.

Of great concern are risqué or sexual posts by high school and college students on websites or Facebook. Of even greater concern are risky portrayals of sexuality on dating websites. One study showed young men who were exposed to pornography were less likely to use a condom than were those who were not (Luder et al., 2011). Another study of a teen dating website revealed that over 15% of female posts contain explicit sexuality or nudity (Pujazon-Zazik, Manasse, & Orrell-Valente, 2012), putting them in danger from cyberstalkers and sexual predators. Many teens and young adults fail to consider that sexual postings are available widely to friends as well as enemies, predators, teachers, and potential employers. So as with anything you put on the Internet, think before you post.

Research suggests the female sex drive is more socially flexible, culturally responsive, and adaptable than the male sex drive, which is more predictable and consistent, less shaped by culture, and somewhat stronger (Baumeister, 2000; Diamond, 2012; Vohs et al., 2004; Wells & Twenge, 2005); although research suggests that men and women are more similar than different in their sex drives (Benuto & Meana, 2008). Some women seem to do fine without sex, while other women are highly sexual, depending on circumstances (Baumeister, 2000) and are more satisfied with their sexual relationships than men regardless of how much sex they are having (Holmberg & Blair, 2009). Numerous studies show individual women vary in sex drive over time. For example, a woman may have a stronger sex drive when she is in an intimate relationship than when she is not involved with anyone. Men, by contrast, have a more consistent sex drive that operates regardless of their relational involvement with someone. Heterosexual women are aroused by a greater variety of stimuli (e.g., affectionate behaviors, romantic context) than are heterosexual men, who are more likely to be aroused primarily by sights and thoughts of attractive women (Chivers & Bailey, 2005; Chivers, Soto, & Blanchard, 2007) and have a stable erotic compass. Of course, the popularity of Viagra and Cialis suggests that men's sex drive is also somewhat variable.

Female sexuality is also more varied across different sociocultural settings than is male sexuality. Baumeister (2000) cited ethnographic studies that report much greater cross-cultural variation in sexual behavior for females than for males. For example, in some cultures, women have premarital sex while in others they do not. A worldwide survey reveals that in countries where women have more equality they engage in more casual sex, have more partners in their lifetime, and have sex at an earlier age (Baumeister & Mendoza, 2011). Studies

also show that women are less likely to reveal their true sexual attitudes than are men if social norms require them to hide their sexual interest so as to not appear “loose” (DeLamater & Hyde, 2004).

Men and women also think about sex differently. Men have greater expectations for sex on dates (Mongeau, Jacobsen, & Donnerstein, 2007; Mongeau & Johnson, 1995) and may feel social pressure and gain status by having sex (Sweeney, 2014). Men also think about sex more often, as much as every few seconds (Fisher, Moore, & Pittinger, 2012; Vohs et al., 2004); although they also think more about food and sleep than women do. Men are more motivated to date to have sexual relations, less willing to live without sex (Mongeau et al., 2004; Regan & Berscheid, 1995), more liberal in sexual attitudes (Benuto & Meana, 2008), and are more likely to think of the advantages of sexual relations rather than the disadvantages (Kisler & Christopher, 2008). Men are more likely than women to regret *not having* a sexual relationship; women regret sexual action and inaction equally (Roose et al., 2006).

Studies also show differences in sexual behavior as well. Men tend to look at women longer and more sexually than women look at men (Lykins, Meana, & Strauss, 2008). Men are also more likely to engage in short-term mating opportunities, particularly with physically attractive women (Van Straaten et al., 2008), more likely to want a friends-with-benefits relationship (Akbulut & Weger, 2016), and to view pornographic material on the Internet. When women do view pornography on the Internet, they tend to keep it secret (Internet Filter Learning Center, 2012). (See [Box 9.1](#) for more information on cybersex, including sex differences.) Men have more sex partners (Willett et al., 2004), are less monogamous, and are more likely to believe that monogamy is a sacrifice (Schmookler & Bursic, 2007). Interestingly, the first act of sexual intercourse between two people usually has a much more positive effect on the relationship for women than for men, assuming that the sex was a voluntary act reflecting love and commitment (Cate et al., 1993).

Sex in Same-Sex Relationships

Significant minorities of people are not sexually attracted to members of the opposite sex but rather have same-sex attractions. Like Taylor, who we introduced in the opening scenario, most homosexuals have early recollections of same-sex attraction and a clear sense that they were different from the majority as early as preschool. Research suggests that throughout the world, most gay men and lesbians experienced some degree of gender nonconformity as children (Crooks & Baur, 1999). Studies show that sexual attraction is more than mere preference; gay men show the most sexual response to gay scenes, bisexual men to bisexual scenes, and straight men to heterosexual interactions (Cerny & Janssen, 2011; Rosenthal, Sylva, Safron, & Bailey, 2011).

Because men and women differ in their sexual attitudes and behaviors, it is not surprising that relationships between lesbians, gay men, and heterosexuals also differ to some degree. Yet there are major similarities between heterosexual, gay, and lesbian relationships as well (Holmberg & Blair, 2009; Holmberg et al., 2010). Like heterosexual couples, the vast majority of lesbians and gay men want intimacy and long-term committed relationships (Frost & Gola, 2015; Peplau, Fingerhut, & Beals, 2004). Even when same-sex marriage was illegal in most states, the majority of lesbians and gay men would have married their partner if it was legal (Peplau et al., 2004). Interestingly, some studies have shown that gay men and lesbians report higher levels of sexual satisfaction than do heterosexual couples (Holmberg & Blair, 2009).

Despite increasingly progressive attitudes about homosexuality and bisexuality in the United States, gay and lesbian relationships are still not readily accepted or understood by many segments of society (Callender, 2015; Peplau et al., 2004). This may be the reason, even today, that gays and lesbians are more likely to meet partners for dates and hookups online (Kuperberg & Padgett, 2015) rather than in bars or at parties. Growing up gay in a heterosexual, homophobic world is not easy, and most problems for gay men and lesbians come from adverse reactions of society. Even today, publicly gay men experience more anxiety and depression than do closeted men (Pachankis, Cochran, & Mays, 2015). Adolescence is a tough time for all young people, as indicated by the high teenage suicide rate. The rate is even higher for gay teens, who may need counseling as they adjust to their sexual orientation and to the attitudes of those around them.

Sex in Lesbian Relationships

Compared to heterosexual couples and gay male couples, lesbians report the highest level of relational satisfaction (Kurdek, 2008) and the lowest level of sexual victimization (Johnson, Matthews, & Napper, 2016). Over 75% of lesbian couples are monogamous; fidelity is especially important to lesbians (Blumstein & Schwartz, 1983); moreover, monogamy in lesbian couples has increased over the past 40 years (Gota et al., 2011). Unlike men, lesbians are less attracted to women based on physical attraction. Sexual activity for lesbians declines over time, leading to concerns and even jokes about the “lesbian bed death” (Peplau et al., 2004; Van Rosmalen-Nooijens, Vergeer, Lagro-Janssen, 2008). Although the frequency of sexual relations is associated with increased satisfaction in lesbian couples (Peplau et al., 2004), lesbians have sex less frequently than male gay couples, heterosexual daters, or married couples (Blumstein & Schwartz, 1983), which is consistent with variability in all women’s sexual desire (Diamond, 2012). Women generally are taught to be selective in choosing sexual partners, to take a reactive rather than proactive role in sexual situations, and to act as gatekeepers who decide whether sexual activity will take place. Lesbians must renegotiate these gender roles so that they feel comfortable initiating sex. Moreover, since men have a more consistent sex drive than women (Baumeister, 2000), with no man to initiate sex, sex is less likely to occur. Among lesbian women, acceptance of oneself as a lesbian is associated with sexual satisfaction (Henderson, Lehavot, & Simoni, 2009). Finally, lesbians may be satisfied with nongenital sex since, like heterosexual women, lesbians value physical contact, such as hugging and cuddling, and are likely to consider these ends in and of themselves rather than a prelude to sex (Blumstein & Schwartz, 1983).

Prior research suggests that between a quarter and third of lesbians have been married to men (Boon & Alderson, 2009). Some may be bisexual, others may be testing their heterosexual orientation, and still others may be concealing their homosexual orientation. According to Bell and Weinberg (1978), relational satisfaction is low in such marital relationships, and most end in separation or divorce. Over 75% of lesbians have had at least one sexual encounter with a man (Reinisch & Beasley, 1990), and numerous young women who report being only attracted to men still report sexual activity with other women (McCabe, Brewster, & Tillman, 2011). As discussed previously, research suggests that women are more sexually variable than men and have an easier time accepting various sexual orientations and conditions, including homosexuality or abstinence (Baumeister, 2000).

Sex in Relationships Between Gay Men

According to the Kinsey report, although about one third of all men have engaged in homosexual behavior at one time in their lives, only about 8% have had exclusively gay relationships for 3 or more years, and only 4% have been exclusively gay throughout their lives. About two thirds of gay men have had sex with a woman, and 10% to 15% of gay men may be more accurately viewed as bisexual (Reinisch & Beasley, 1990).

On average, gay men have more sex partners and engage in sex more often than lesbians or heterosexuals (Blumstein & Schwartz, 1983; Kelly, Bimbi, Nanin, Iziennicki, & Parsons, 2009; Parsons et al., 2008). Because women often act as sexual gatekeepers, the absence of a woman in a relationship probably reduces restraint and increases sexual frequency. Gay men are also more likely than lesbians or heterosexuals to be in nonmonogamous relationships. In the 1970s and 1980s, over 80% of gay men were nonmonogamous, but by 2000 that number had dropped to less than 60% (Blumstein & Schwartz, 1983; Gota et al., 2011). Long-term relationships among gay men are much more common than the media would have us believe. The Kinsey data suggest that virtually all gay men have had a steady, highly committed gay relationship that lasted 1 to 3 years (Reinisch & Beasley, 1990) and for those gay men in long-term relationships, satisfaction increases over time (Kurdek, 2008). Furthermore, some evidence suggests that gay men, like heterosexual men and women, have become more monogamous since the AIDS epidemic first emerged in the 1980s (Gota et al., 2011; Sprecher & Regan, 2000).

Gay men may have difficulty negotiating sexual initiation precisely because it is typically a male prerogative. In short, some gay men resent the other male's initiation and refuse sex, which can lead to conflict. Gay men have more sex than other couple types since either partner can feel free to initiate sex (Blumstein & Schwartz, 1983; Parsons et al., 2008), and most gay men are highly satisfied with their sexual relationships. How to initiate sex may sometimes be difficult, since kissing, which is a more feminine behavior, is often the gateway to sexual relations and is most likely in lesbian relationships, moderately likely in heterosexual relationships, and least likely in gay relationships between men (Blumstein & Schwartz, 1983).

Sexual Attitudes

Deciding if and when to have sex is a personal choice influenced by many factors, including levels of commitment and passion, alcohol consumption, and moral values. Sexual behavior is strongly related to people's attitudes, for people may be born with a number of sexual preferences and proclivities, but most attitudes and beliefs about sex are learned. For example, a person might be physically aroused and curious when thinking about having sex, but moral attitudes and beliefs might stop the individual from acting on the impulse to have sex.

The social norms of one's culture also influence people's sexual attitudes. Attitudes toward sexuality, particularly premarital and female sexuality, became increasingly liberal in the United States during the 20th century (Sprecher & McKinney, 1993; Twenge et al., 2015; Wells & Twenge, 2005). The best data on changes in sexuality come from a study by Wells and Twenge (2005) that aggregated over 500 studies including over 250,000 participants. Throughout most of the century, premarital sex was considered unacceptable, particularly for women. But "premarital sexual activity has become normative for today's youth. Rates of sexual intercourse for teens have increased dramatically since the early 1960s" (Christopher & Roosa, 1991, p. 11).

Positive attitudes toward sexual activity, especially among females, steadily increased from 1965 to 2012 (Twenge et al., 2015; Wells & Twenge, 2005). In the 1950s, only 13% of teenage girls were sexually active whereas by the 1990s, 47% were sexually active. Before 1970, the average age for first sexual intercourse for men was 18 and for women was 19; by the late 1990s, this average had dropped to age 15 for both genders (Wells & Twenge, 2005). Similarly, before 1970, less than half of teenagers had engaged in oral sex, but by the 1990s over two thirds of both men and women had engaged in oral sex. In the late 1950s, only 12% of young women approved of premarital sex, and by the 1980s about three quarters approved. The only sexual behavior not increasing is the number of partners, which has remained fairly constant over the years, especially since news of the AIDS epidemic in the 1980s (Wells & Twenge, 2005). But times have changed; by the 21st century, over 80% of men and women have had premarital sexual intercourse (Willett et al., 2004).

The revolution in sexual attitudes that began in the 1960s was due to a number of factors. The 1960s was a revolutionary era for all types of values, including those associated with politics, music, the environment, civil rights, and women's rights. In the 1960s, images of sexuality were widely depicted in the mass media through magazines, books, and movies, and to a lesser degree, television. Perhaps the biggest factor was the birth control pill—the first simple and effective technology that permitted sex without reproduction. For the first time in human history, women could have sexual relationships without risking pregnancy. Scholars suggest that the sexual revolution of the 1960s and 1970s was mainly a change in women's values, with men remaining much the same (Baumeister, 2000). Today, teens and young adults are much more sexually active than they were before the sexual revolution of the 1960s.

Researchers have identified three types of sexual attitudes held by people today (Sprecher & McKinney, 1993). Some people have a **procreational orientation**, which reflects the belief that producing offspring is the

primary purpose of sexual intercourse. Other people have a **relational orientation**, which holds that sexual intercourse is a way of expressing love and affection, and developing greater relational intimacy. Still others have a **recreational orientation**, viewing sex as a primary source of fun, escape, excitement, or pleasure. The procreational orientation, the position taken by most major religions, is associated with traditional, conservative cultural values. The relational orientation, which is equated with moderate sexual values, is widespread in the United States. People with this orientation disapprove of casual sex but usually approve of premarital sex in the context of a committed or loving relationship. The recreational orientation is a sexually liberal view holding that sex is appropriate between consenting adults regardless of their relationship (or lack thereof).

These orientations are not mutually exclusive; many people's sexual attitudes are some combination of procreational, relational, and recreational. Indeed, most married couples in the United States embrace elements of all three values within their relationship at different times. By contrast, attitudes toward premarital sex vacillate between a relational orientation and a somewhat recreational orientation in the United States but are rarely procreational. Research has shown that couples are more likely to endorse increased sexual activity, including sexual intercourse, as the relationship becomes closer (Sprecher, McKinney, Walsh, & Anderson, 1988). For several decades, people in the United States have subscribed primarily to a relational orientation through the practice of **serial monogamy** (Christopher & Roosa, 1991; Sorensen, 1973). These couples are sexually active only with each other (monogamy) and do not engage in other sexual relationships until the current relationship ends.

While a lot of research has focused on the dark side of premarital sex, such as disease, pregnancy, and abortion, positive outcomes also occur. Most premarital sex takes place in an intimate and committed relationship that provides support and often leads to marriage (Christopher & Roosa, 1991). In fact, early research showed that serial monogamists, people who have one sexual relationship at a time, overwhelmingly loved each other and had healthy, caring sexual relationships (Sorensen, 1973). Moreover, serial monogamists had the highest school grades, were most likely to use birth control, enjoyed sex more, and were generally better adjusted than were either promiscuous adventurers or virgins. Recent research has shown that adolescents who engage in normative sexual behavior are better adjusted psychologically and more positive about life than are adolescents who are sexually inexperienced (Vrangalova & Savin-Williams, 2011).

Although most college students are sexually experienced, some choose to remain virgins. In a study of sexual behavior of college students, Sprecher and Regan (1996) found that 11% of men and 13% of women were virgins; although virtually all of the virgins reported experiencing sexual desire. Thus, Sarah, who we introduced at the beginning of this chapter, is not alone in her virginity. Women like Sarah give several reasons for being a virgin, including the absence of a long-term or love relationship, fear of negative consequences such as pregnancy or STIs, personal beliefs and values, and feelings of inadequacy or insecurity. All of these reasons are stronger for women than for men. In Sprecher and Regan's study, virgins reported a mixture of pride and anxiety about their status; although positive emotions outweighed negative ones. Women were more likely to be proud and happy about keeping their virginity, while men were more likely to be embarrassed about it. Men are reluctant virgins; most are virgins because their partner is not willing (Sprecher

& Treger, 2015). Virgins and adolescents who have not engaged in oral sex are more likely to be traditionally religious, and religious individuals are more positive about their status as virgins than less religious virgins (Burris, Smith, & Carlson, 2009; Sprecher & Regan, 1996; Vazsonyi & Jenkins, 2010). Interestingly, however, for young adults, spirituality, when defined as a search for sacredness and transcendence, is associated with increased sexual activity (Burris et al., 2009).

Developing Sexual Attitudes and Beliefs

Aside from historical forces, how do people develop sexual attitudes and beliefs? We have already touched on one important source—culture. Sexual attitudes and knowledge come from many other sources as well, including mass media, parents, peers, and past relationships (Andersen, 1993). These factors influence more than sexual attitudes; they also influence sexual behavior and communication about sex.

Culture

Culture influences sexual attitudes. Andersen (1998a) argued that “the most basic force that molds and shapes human beings, other than our membership in the human race itself, is culture” (p. 48). Culture is resistant to change, and people usually adopt the values and attitudes of their parents and their culture unless very strong countervailing forces come into play. Children of immigrants, for example, are caught between two sets of cultural values—(1) those of their parents and (2) those of their peers. Sexual attitudes change slowly across each generation and still show cultural influences after 100 or more years of cultural assimilation. In the United States, African Americans have the most permissive sexual attitudes, followed by whites, while people from Asian, Latino, and Middle Eastern cultures have the most conservative sexual orientations (Sprecher & McKinney, 1993). Among white Americans, particularly women, and to a lesser degree among African Americans, talking about sexual intimacy is quite common and is believed to be the heart and soul of a good relationship (Crooks & Baur, 1999). By contrast, Asian Americans and Hispanic Americans tend to be more reluctant to discuss their sexual relationship. In interethnic couples, these differences require considerable understanding and adaptation by the partners. For more on how culture impacts sexual attitudes and behaviors, see [Box 9.2](#).

The Media

Both the mass media and social media are important sources of sexual information. Research has shown that 29% of interactions on prime-time television depict sexual issues that emphasize male sexual roles and a recreational rather than a procreational sex orientation (Ward, 1995). Most of these interactions depict sex as a competition and equate masculinity with being sexual. The media also influences **sexual scripts** for communicating about sex. Magazines are an important information source about sex and sexual issues. Starting in 1953 with the publication of *Playboy*, people from the United States were introduced to open nudity on newsstands and perhaps, more importantly, to the “playboy” philosophy that rejected limits on sexual expression, condoned any form of consensual sex, and was critical of the institution of marriage (D’Emilio & Freedman, 1988). Similarly, publication of Helen Gurley Brown’s (1962) *Sex and the Single Girl* in the early 1960s urged young women to reconsider the taboo against premarital sex. Research suggests that

when young males view men's movies and men's magazines it affects the way they think about sex and behave by fostering male sexual privilege, having more sexual partners, and rejecting abstinence before marriage (Ward, Epstein, Caruthers, & Merriwether, 2011). But media facilitates healthy sex practices, too. Viewing dramas that feature frank discussions about sex facilitate sexual communication among viewers that promoted open conversations about sex 2 weeks after viewing (Moyer-Guse, Chung, & Jain, 2011).

Box 9.2 Around the World: Sexuality and Culture: The Abnormal is Normal

Every culture has at least one thing in common: Its residents engage in sexual behavior since sex is necessary for procreation.

Cultures that did not engage in sexual intercourse are all extinct. But much of the similarity ends there! Cultures differ widely in the time, place, motivation, and appropriateness for sexual interaction. As we discuss in this chapter, couples from the United States have sex to recreate, relate, and procreate. Of course, many young people in the United States, especially males, adopt a recreational orientation to sex if they are not in an exclusive romantic relationship. When partners develop a close relationship, they usually move to a more relational orientation with sex seen as a way to create and maintain closeness in their relationship.

In some cultures in other parts of the world, people have a purely procreational orientation toward sex. This is particularly true in cultures with fundamentalist religious beliefs (Andersen, 2011a). In Islamic cultures, among Hindus, and among truly fundamentalist Christians, virginity at marriage is expected, particularly for women. In the United States, virginity at marriage is increasingly uncommon (Andersen, 2008). At the other end of the spectrum are Northern European countries that are far more liberal than the United States about premarital sex, single parenthood, and nudity.

Sex is treated very differently by different cultures and different individuals. Since sexual behavior is so diverse, a significant relational challenge is to find a partner who is sexually compatible or at least accommodating to your personal sexual beliefs and behaviors. Sex is an extremely personal act, and we all have our own personal and cultural beliefs about what is appropriate and satisfying.

Sexual material on the Internet is a concern of parents, educators, and politicians. Cybersex may be a negative influence with increasingly bizarre or violent effects, or it may be a harmless form of safe sex with beneficial cathartic effects for adults (see [Box 9.1](#) earlier in this chapter). Research suggests that adolescent and young adult women on social media sites may flaunt sexuality, disclose excessively, and risk connection with predators (Theil-Stern, 2009). The practice of “sexting” is widespread among teens and young adults creating legal issues regarding pornography, causing potential image problems for sexters in the future, creating a potential jaded view of sexuality and encouraging sexual predators (Lenhart, 2009). On the other hand, over 20% of young adults turn to online information about sexual health that may be hard to talk about face to face, so like other media, the Internet and social media may have negative and positive effects on the development of sexual attitudes and behavior.

Parents

Children learn about sex and relationships from their parents both indirectly and directly. Indirectly, parents serve as models for children. If parents are affectionate or sexual toward each other, children will expect their own romantic relationships to include affection or sex. Kids pick up attitudes about sex from their families through modelling and body language. As a result, people raised with more conservative family values are more erotophobic and experience more sexual guilt and anxiety (Simpson, Wilson, & Winterheld, 2004). Children of more religious parents are less likely to engage in risky sexual behaviors and have less sexually permissive peers (Landor, Simons, Simons, Brody, & Gibbens, 2011). Loving, involved parents have positive effects on their children’s sexual behavior including delayed sexual intercourse, greater condom use, more sexual autonomy, greater likelihood of sex occurring only in an existing relationship, and less anxiety on the part of the child (Afifi, Joseph, & Aldeis, 2008; Parkes, Henderson, Wight, & Nixon, 2011). Parents also influence their children directly by talking to them about sex, particularly when it occurs during the early teen years, yet parent–child communication about sex is rare (Byers, 2011; Fisher, 2004; Warren, 1995), and

teenagers often feel uncomfortable talking to parents about sex, primarily because the parents issue orders or warnings rather than frankly discussing sexual thoughts and feelings (Brock & Jennings, 1993). As a result, parents are amazingly unaware of their teenage offspring's sexual behavior (Fisher, 2004). Within families, teens report being most comfortable talking to a same-sex older sibling or same-sex parent about sex (Guerrero & Afifi, 1995b), and mothers and daughters are more likely to talk about sex than are fathers and sons (Fisher, 2004).

Peers

Rogers (1995) showed that most diffusion of information about a variety of topics, including sexually related ones, occurs interpersonally between people who are similar to one another. Sprecher and McKinney (1993) showed that peers have more influence on people's sexual standards than parents. Male adolescents are notorious for instilling attitudes about what constitutes a physically attractive woman, what constitutes masculine behavior, and the importance of sexual conquests. Females share all manner of relational and sexual information with one another regarding birth control methods, and the quality of individual males as potential mates. Sexual attitudes and behaviors are also modelled by friends and then imitated.

Past Relationships

Many attitudes about sex result from prior relational experiences. People who have learned to trust others and to be comfortable with closeness tend to be more monogamous in their sexual relationships (Simpson & Gangestad, 1991). Moreover, having a partner who provides consistent, loving, physical contact helps build an individual's self-esteem and sets up positive expectations for future relationships (Hazan & Zeifman, 1994). In contrast, people who are uncomfortable with closeness and have had unsatisfying sexual relationships in the past will be more likely to desire short-term, casual sex than committed relationships (Brennan & Shaver, 1995; Stephan & Bachman, 1999). Frequent, casual sex has trade-offs. Research shows that people with many casual sexual partners are more likely to have close friends, less likely to experience loneliness, but more likely to have experienced relational aggression and sexually based prejudice (Vrangalova & Bukberg, 2015). Those who have been hurt in past love relationships are less likely to experience highly passionate or obsessive love in the future (Stephan & Bachman, 1999). Together, these findings suggest that people who have had positive sexual experiences in committed relationships are most likely to expect future relationships to be monogamous and sexually satisfying. Past sexual relationships can also affect attraction. Sprecher and Regan (2000) concluded the following:

In general, research indicates that low to moderate levels of current or past sexual activity and the restriction of sexual activity to committed relationships are more likely to increase one's desirability as a partner than is a history of many sexual partners or casual sexual activity. (p. 219)

Communication About Sex

Along with sexual attitudes, the way people communicate about sex can influence the course that a relationship takes as well as how satisfied couples are. Research on courtship patterns and flirtation provides insight on how romantic and sexual relationships develop. Studies have also shown how communication about sex keeps relationships satisfying. Work on sexual scripts often focuses on how communication is used to initiate and refuse sex. Finally, research on **pillow talk** describes how people communicate following sexual encounters.

Courtship and Flirtation

When people flirt, they typically use indirect communication strategies to convey their interest and attraction, especially when they are in the early stages of a relationship. Nonverbal flirtation displays are more common than verbal cues (Beres, Herold, & Maitland, 2004). Gazes, smiles, warm vocal tones, and close distances are key flirtatious behaviors (Givens, 1978, 1983; Moore, 1985; Muehlenhard, Koralewski, Andrews, & Burdick, 1986). Indirect nonverbal cues are often used because they provide protection from potential rejection. The receiver can simply ignore these nonverbal cues without having to verbally reject the flirtatious person. The flirtatious person can deny flirting and simply feign friendliness. Sometimes, of course, direct verbal strategies are used, such as telling people they look sexy or talking about sex. These more direct strategies, however, are more likely to be used in an established romantic relationship. There are also differences in people's motivations and style of flirting (Hall, Carter, Cody, & Albright, 2010). Five different flirting styles—the **traditional flirting style**, the **physical flirting style**, the **sincere flirting style**, the **playful flirting style**, and the **polite flirting style**—are described in [Box 9.3](#).

Schefflen's (1965, 1974) model of the courtship process sought to explain how various nonverbal behaviors unfold over time to signal availability and sexual interest. Schefflen's model includes five stages, with the earlier stages characterized by the most indirect communication. The courtship behaviors in this model often reflect attentiveness, approachability, and submissiveness. Thus, potential partners must gain one another's attention and signal that they are available for communication. Submissive behaviors that communicate a desire for intimacy are particularly useful during the courtship process because they are seen as a nonthreatening, playful way to convey sexual interest. Some submissive behaviors, such as stroking someone's hair in a comforting way, also mirror those used in parent-child relationship to convey caring and intimacy.

The Attention Stage

The goal of the first stage in Schefflen's model, the **attention stage**, is to get the other person's attention and to present oneself in the best possible light—either strategically or accidentally. When Taylor met Leslie with a group at dinner, she made sure she was in a good location to converse with her. At the table, she made sure that she was seated near her to encourage interaction. Throughout history, people have practiced the art of gaining attention as a precursor to courtship. In 19th-century America, it was common for women to drop something, such as a glove or handkerchief, in front of a man whom they wanted to get to know. The man, if

polite, was obliged to retrieve the dropped item and to turn his attention to the woman. Similarly, men commonly asked to be formally introduced to a woman—often by a relative or friend—before pursuing a conversation. Any place where singles gather, we are likely to see a variety of attention-getting strategies, such as Taylor positioning herself in Leslie's view and trying to catch her eye. These behaviors are indirect, including demure glances, tentative smiles, anxious movements such as twisting the ring on one's finger, and primping behavior such as fixing one's hair, applying lipstick, or straightening one's tie.

Box 9.3 Highlights: The Five Flirting Styles

People take different approaches to flirting based on their attitudes and goals. Hall and his colleagues (2010) identified five styles. You likely identify more strongly with one or two of these than the others. Your style might also vary based on who you are flirting with and what your goals are.

The Traditional Style: This style is based on the traditional belief that men chase whereas women respond to men's advances. Men communicate their interest more verbally than women. Women show interest primarily through nonverbal cues. People endorsing this style believe that "Men should make the first move" and their behavior is guided by social norms.

The Physical Style: This style is based on communicating sexual and romantic interest, and likely includes more references to physical appearance as well as more touching and sexual innuendo. People endorsing this style believe that they are good at showing their sexual interest to others and they are motivated by romantic interest.

The Sincere Style: This style is based on creating an emotional bond, and is often perceived as an honest and effective way to make a real connection with someone. People endorsing this style say that they "really look for an emotional connection with someone" and are motivated to get to know the person better.

The Playful Style: This style is based on the idea that flirting can be fun and does not necessarily need to be tied to starting a relationship with someone. People endorsing this style say they flirt with people who they are not really interested in, they flirt to feel good about themselves, and they don't take flirting seriously.

The Polite Style: This style revolves around caution and the idea that expression of sexual interest is inappropriate. People who endorse this style are typically conservative and believe that "being too physical can be a turn-off." Sometimes they also assume that the other person does not want a relationship with them.

The Courtship Readiness Stage

During the **courtship readiness stage**, or what is sometimes referred to as the *recognition stage*, the initiator of the flirtation determines whether the other person is approachable for interaction. For example, if Taylor's eye contact and friendliness is met with Leslie's cold stare or annoyed glance, or is ignored, the courtship process will end. Similarly, if Leslie is busy interacting with other people, Taylor will probably hesitate to approach unless she receives a fairly clear signal of interest. Typical flirting behaviors include sustained mutual gaze and smiling, raised eyebrows, direct body orientation, head tilts in the direction of the other person, and nervous laughter. More grooming behavior also tends to occur in this stage, with people tucking in their stomachs, arranging their clothing and hair, and wetting their lips as they prepare to approach one another.

The Positioning Stage

If Taylor and Leslie are attracted to each other, they will engage in a series of positioning behaviors that signal availability for interaction while indicating to others that they are, at least temporarily, a "couple" and so should be left alone. Close distancing and face-to-face body orientation are typical in the **positioning stage**, as are forward leans. Partners also gaze and smile at each other and display interest and animation through gestures and expressive voices. If the relationship is progressing, hand-holding is a common romantic or sexual escalation event (O'Sullivan, Cheng, Harris, & Brooks-Gunn, 2007). If the setting is quiet, Taylor and Leslie may lower their voices to draw each other closer. In this stage, communication becomes more synchronized; that is, turn taking becomes smoother, and partners engage in similar behaviors such as crossing their legs. Although there is a marked increase in the intimacy of communication at this stage, some

submissiveness and ambiguity still remain. For example, if Taylor and Leslie gaze for too long into each other's eyes, they might feel embarrassed, avert their eyes, and laugh nervously.

The Invitations and Sexual Arousal Stage

Taylor and Leslie are very attracted to each other and are moving into the fourth stage—the **invitations and sexual arousal stage**. The beginning of this stage is marked by subtle touch and sexual contact. For example, Taylor might put her hand on Leslie's knee or stroke her back to see how she responds. More subtle signs of intimacy include grooming the partner, performing carrying and clutching activities, and acting sexually provocative (Burgoon et al., 2010; Givens, 1978; Schefflen, 1965). Widespread among primates including humans, grooming behaviors include adjusting a partner's clothing, pushing a stray strand of hair out of someone's eyes, and affectionate stroking touches that appear to have functional qualities (Dunbar, 2010). These seemingly innocuous behaviors release oxytocin (OT) and endorphins, chemicals that are keys to bonding, trust, and pleasure. Carrying and clutching behaviors include carrying someone's bags or books, holding hands, and leaning on someone's arm for support, behaviors that promote trust and reciprocity. Sexually provocative actions include dancing in a suggestive way, revealing body parts by unbuttoning one's shirt or crossing one's leg to expose more thigh, and touching the partner in intimate places.

The Resolution Stage

If Taylor's invitation is accepted and sexual interaction occurs, Taylor and Leslie have reached the final stage, the **resolution stage**. Of course, determining whether the invitation is accepted is not always easy, especially if the behaviors used in the sexual arousal and invitations stage were indirect and ambiguous. When people move through the courtship stages rapidly, the intent of both partners might be unclear. Perhaps Leslie was just being friendly while Taylor was interested in a sexual relationship. Sometimes people engage in sexual teasing, a behavior that is more commonly used by women (Meston & O'Sullivan, 2007) and which can be misconstrued as real sexual interest.

Some studies have shown that men are more likely than women to see flirtatious behaviors as seductive, whereas women often see these same behaviors as ways of being friendly and expressing innocent attraction (Abbey, 1982, 1987; Abbey & Melby, 1986). To complicate matters even further, research has shown that people flirt for a variety of reasons, only one of which is to signal sexual interest. For example, people may flirt because they see it as playful fun, they want to make a third party jealous, they want to develop their social skills, or they are trying to persuade someone to do something for them (Afifi, Guerrero, & Egland, 1994; Koeppel, Montagne-Miller, O'Hair, & Cody, 1993). Thus, when someone is flirting, the person may or may not be showing sexual interest.

In longer courtships, couples spend considerable time in the sexual arousal and invitations stage, with sexual intimacy increasing slowly over time. Partners are more likely to be direct about their intentions, but misunderstandings can still occur. Sometimes one person is ready to have sex before the other, and one partner may view intimate touch as a way to express closeness while the other sees it as a prelude to sex. Partners must negotiate if and when sex occurs, often through both verbal and nonverbal communication. If

one or both of the partners does not want to have sex, they are entering the first four of Schefflen's stages are referred to as **quasi-courtship** rather than courtship. Misinterpretation of flirtatious cues is likely, given that the first three of four stages often look the same, regardless of whether they are quasi-courtship or true courtship stages.

It is important to note that these courtship stages provide only a rough guide for how people signal romantic interest and increase sexual involvement. Couples are unique and progress at different speeds. A relatively small number of couples have sex on a first date or shortly after the partners meet; most couples wait until some level of intimacy has developed before having sex. With this in mind, Christopher and Cate (1985) identified four types of couples. **Rapid-involvement couples** have high levels of physical arousal and have sex on the first date or shortly thereafter. For these partners, sexual intimacy often precedes psychological intimacy. **Gradual-involvement couples** let sexual involvement increase gradually as the relationship develops and becomes more psychologically intimate. Sexual involvement moves through stages with sexual involvement increasing as the partners move from a first date, to a casually dating relationship, to a more serious, committed relationship. **Delayed-involvement couples** wait until the two people consider themselves to be a committed couple to become sexually involved. For these couples, psychological intimacy precedes sexual intimacy. **Low-involvement couples** usually wait to have sex until the partners are engaged or married. Research suggests that most couples in the United States define themselves as falling under either the gradual- (31%) or delayed-involvement (44%) category, with around 17% identifying themselves as low involvement and 7% classifying themselves as rapid involvement (Christopher & Cate, 1985; Sprecher & McKinney, 1993). These findings correspond with research showing that most people have a relational orientation toward sex.

Communication, Sexual Satisfaction, and Relational Satisfaction

Beyond courtship, the relational orientation suggests that established couples use sexual interaction to express love, attraction, and desire to one another. Yet even couples who are in love can be dissatisfied with their sexual relationships. Some relational partners think sex is a taboo topic and so do not talk about their sexual desires and preferences (Baxter & Wilmot, 1985). Yet studies suggest that communication about sex is extremely important. Research shows that sexual self-disclosure is associated with a satisfying and rewarding relationship (MacNeil & Byers, 2009). Frank, Anderson, and Rubinstein (1979) found that about half of husbands and three fourths of wives reported having some sexual difficulty in their marriages, and that these difficulties were increased by poor communication skills.

Direct communication about sex facilitates satisfaction. Sexual satisfaction and relationship satisfaction are positively correlated across a variety of relationship types (Birnie-Porter & Hunt, 2015; Henderson et al., 2009), but communication appears to tie these two forms of satisfaction together. Indeed, Cupach and Comstock (1990) found that good communication about sex leads to greater sexual satisfaction, which in turn contributes to more relational satisfaction. Research also suggests that men prefer clear, instrumental disclosure about sex because it leads to greater sexual understanding and, in turn, to more sexual satisfaction (MacNeil & Byers, 2005, 2009). Indeed, indirect communication about sex decreases sexual satisfaction for

both men and women (Theiss, 2011), whereas direct communication increases both sexual satisfaction and overall relational satisfaction (Montesi, Fauber, Gordon, & Heimberg, 2010). If you are currently in a sexual relationship, you can access your level of sexual communication satisfaction by taking the test in [Box 9.4](#).

A common misconception is that men enjoy sexual intercourse more than women. The reality is that heterosexual men and women both enjoy intercourse. Contrary to the stereotype, some research suggests that women may actually enjoy intercourse more than men (Blumstein & Schwartz, 1983). In close, committed relationships, most women enjoy sexual intercourse because of the extreme intimacy and closeness it reflects. Although some women may not want to have sex as often as men, when they do have high-quality sex, they report finding it extremely pleasurable. A study of university students (Higgins, Mullanax, Trussell, Davidson, & Moore, 2011) found that the vast majority of both males and females experienced high or very high levels of sexual satisfaction and rarely felt uncomfortable or guilty about having sex. This study found that lack of guilt, frequency of orgasm, and comfort with one's sexuality were positively associated with sexual satisfaction for both men and women. Indeed, nonverbally expressing sexual pleasure during sex is associated with one's own and one's partner's sexual satisfaction (Babin, 2013). Other studies have shown that sex can reduce stress and enhance feelings of well-being (Shrier, Shih, Hacker, & de Moor, 2007; Wright, Parkes, Strange, Allen, & Bonell, 2008).

Another common misconception is that the most important predictor of sexual satisfaction is how often a couple has sex. Nearly 90% of married individuals report that they are sexually satisfied, with couples varying considerably in how often they have sex; indeed, most studies show little or no relationship between amount of sex and satisfaction (Blumstein & Schwartz, 1983; Sprecher & Cate, 2004). Frequency of sex is not as important as the quality of the sex and the match between two people's needs during sexual activity (Sprecher & Regan, 2000). When partners have similar attitudes about sex, they are happier with their sex lives. Therefore, if they believe that cuddling is more important than sex, they might have sex less often than a couple who believes that sex is the ultimate expression of intimacy; yet both couples would be satisfied.

It is also important to recognize that sexual satisfaction is not the *best* predictor of relational satisfaction in most relationships. As Sprecher and Regan (2000) put it, "Neither the quality nor the quantity of sex might be as important as other nonsexual forms of intimacy in the prediction of relationship satisfaction including expressed affection and supportive communication" (p. 223). These authors noted that sexual dissatisfaction and incompatibility alone are usually not enough to destroy an otherwise close, caring relationship. Only when these sexual problems are "symptomatic of other relational problems" are they likely to lead to conflict and relational termination. The message here is clear: Sexual satisfaction is an important part of romantic relationships, but other factors, such as love, supportiveness, and compatibility, are usually even more important.

Box 9.4 Put Yourself to the Test: Sexual Communication Satisfaction

Think about a current sexual relationship, and rate your communication about sex using the following scale: 1 = strongly disagree and 7 = strongly agree.

	Strongly Disagree				Strongly Agree			
1. I tell my partner when I am especially sexually satisfied.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
2. I am satisfied with my partner's ability to communicate her or his sexual desires to me.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
3. I let my partner know things that I find pleasing during sex.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
4. I do not hesitate to let my partner know when I want to have sex with him or her.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
5. I tell my partner whether or not I am sexually satisfied.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
6. I am satisfied with the degree to which my partner and I talk about the sexual aspects of our relationship.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
7. I am not afraid to show my partner what kind of sexual behavior I like.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
8. I would not hesitate to show my partner what is a sexual turn-on for me.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
9. My partner shows me what pleases her or him during sex.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
10. My partner tells me when he or she is sexually satisfied.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
11. I am pleased with the manner in which my partner and I communicate with each other about sex.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
12. It is never hard for me to figure out if my partner is sexually satisfied.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	

Add up your answers. A score of 84 indicates maximum sexual communication satisfaction. A score of 12 indicates the lowest level of sexual communication satisfaction possible. Since research shows that sexual communication satisfaction increases as relationships develop, you might want to take this test later in the relationship to see if your score changes.

Source: "The Sexual Communication Satisfaction Scale," From Wheelless, Lawrence R., Wheelless, Virginia Eman, and Baus, Raymond (1984). Sexual communication, communication satisfaction, and solidarity in the development stages of intimate relationships, in *Western Journal of Speech Communication*. 48 (3, Summer), 217–230. Used with permission of the Western States Communication Association.

Sexual Scripts

Scripts are social information that is deployed in everyday interaction. Cultural forces define with whom, when, where, and in what relationships sexual behavior may appropriately be initiated and conducted (Regan & Berscheid, 1999). Sexual scripts most often revolve around the initiation and acceptance or refusal of sexual advances. The North American script casts men as initiators and women as gatekeepers who refuse or accept dates or sexual invitations, particularly in new relationships (Byers, 1996; Mongeau et al., 2004). As Hinde (1984) commented, men seek to propagate widely while women seek to propagate wisely. Research indicates that both men and women are comfortable asking for dates and initiating sexual interaction (Kelley & Rolker-Dolinsky, 1987); although many women think their sexual initiatives might threaten men. However, women are more likely to initiate sexual interaction in well-developed relationships as opposed to developing

relationships.

Negotiating sexual activity in a developing relationship can be difficult because both individuals have multiple goals including managing impressions, providing relational definitions, satisfying sexual desire, following sexual standards or morals, and avoiding disease or pregnancy (Cupach & Metts, 1991). Most sexual initiation attempts are indirect and communicated through nonverbal behavior and flirtation (Andersen, 2008), which may be why face-to-face initiation leads to more relational and sexual satisfaction than online relationship initiation (Blunt-Vinti et al., 2016). Regardless of the medium, friendly behaviors—particularly those by women—are misinterpreted by men as sex-initiating behaviors. To avoid sexually coercive situations (discussed later in this chapter), individuals need to verbally articulate their disinterest, and their partners need to respect their wishes.

Initiation Strategies

Both men and women use persuasive strategies and scripts to initiate dating and sexual relationships. These strategies typically fall into five categories: (1) **hinting and indirect strategies**, (2) **expressions of emotional and physical closeness**, (3) **pressure and manipulation**, (4) **antisocial acts**, and (5) **logic and reasoning** (Christopher & Frandsen, 1990; Edgar & Fitzpatrick, 1988, 1993).

Sexual relations are sensitive and ego threatening, so hinting and indirect strategies can be useful. Romantic conversations are full of indirect communication such as compliments, sexual innuendo, hints, and nonverbal communication. Such ploys are safe because if the partner does not respond sexually, little face is lost. As Edgar and Fitzpatrick (1988) noted, when one person wants to have sex, the situation can be emotionally charged, and an opportunity to save face is welcome. Both men and women are most comfortable with sexual involvement if emotional and physical closeness is present; this is particularly true for women. Establishing a close relationship and sending reassuring relational messages results in increased sexual activity (Christopher & Frandsen, 1990). Doing special things for your partner, telling your partner how much you like her or him, flattering your partner, and sharing time and space with your partner are ways to enhance emotional closeness and initiate sexual activity.

Another sexual influence tactic is logical reasoning by persuading someone that it is advantageous to become sexually involved. This strategy uses logic or negotiates the timing or degree of sexual involvement to overcome a partner's concerns (Christopher & Frandsen, 1990). For example, if Brittany is afraid of getting pregnant or contracting an STI, Chris might make reassuring statements about the effectiveness of condoms or suggest that they both get tested for STIs before having sex. These types of tactics are associated with greater sexual activity in a relationship over the long term, although they may limit or postpone sexual involvement in the short term (Christopher & Frandsen, 1990).

Not surprisingly, men are more likely to use pressure and manipulation to gain sexual compliance than women (Christopher & Frandsen, 1990). These strategies encompass a wide variety of coercive tactics, such as repeated requests for sex, threats to break off or de-escalate the relationship, the use of drugs or alcohol to reduce resistance to sex, and outright deception. These tactics seldom increase the frequency of sexual activity

in a relationship (Christopher & Frandsen, 1990) and can lead to relational dissatisfaction or de-escalation.

Evidence suggests that antisocial acts are unsuccessful in initiating sex in a relationship (Christopher & Frandsen, 1990). These strategies encompass a wide assortment of tactics, including intentionally trying to make the partner jealous (Fleischmann, Spitzberg, Andersen, & Roesch, 2005), pouting or holding a grudge to try to get one's way, and sexual harassment. Such acts may lead to relational termination and even legal action in some cases.

Refusing and Accepting Sexual Invitations

The power to refuse and regulate sex is mainly a woman's prerogative. Across the world, women are more judicious and less casual in their choices about sex than men (Buss, 1994). Men are poor at turning down sex and have few refusal strategies in their repertoire; women regard men's refusals as insincere, unexpected, and upsetting (Metts, Cupach, & Imahori, 1992). This does not imply that women have license to ignore men's refusals; men should be taken as seriously as women when they decline to have sex.

Research suggests that women are well prepared with sexual-compliance-resisting scripts and use multiple resistance strategies (Lannutti & Monahan, 2004; Metts et al., 1992). Women often use indirect strategies because these are perceived as polite; however, more direct strategies seem to be more effective for refusing unwanted sex. Moreover, most men have experienced receiving sexual rejection messages and find them relatively predictable and not particularly disconcerting (Metts et al., 1992). This is useful information for women who use indirect strategies to refuse sex when they are worried about hurting the partner's feelings. Direct strategies are more effective, and thankfully, they are unlikely to be taken personally by men (Motley & Reeder, 1995).

In committed dating relationships, both men and women accept the majority of sexual initiations by their partner (Byers, 1996). In Byers' study, only about 20% of initiations were refused by the partner with about the same percentage for men and women. These data suggest that sex in committed dating relationships is not adversarial and that contrary to the stereotype, in developed relationships, women are more likely to be facilitators of sexual interaction than gatekeepers. In investigating sexual activity among heterosexual daters over a 1-month period, Byers and Lewis (1988) found that nearly half of the couples reported disagreements caused by the man's desire to increase sexual involvement. However, disagreements occurred during just 7% of all dates. Disagreements about sex did occur occasionally over the course of a month, but most dates were free of such disagreements. When sex is refused from a long-term dating partner, the refusal is both unexpected and viewed negatively (Bevan, 2003).

Once sexual activity becomes fairly regular, shared dyadic scripts emerge to guide sexual interaction. In well-developed relationships, women feel freer to initiate touch, affection, and sexual behavior (Cupach & Metts, 1995; Guerrero & Andersen, 1991). Brown and Auerbach (1981) found that wives increased their initiation of sexual activity by about 1% per year of marriage. Several studies have shown that stages of sexual involvement are fairly well scripted, starting with kissing and moving to hand to breast, hand to genitals, oral sex, sexual intercourse, and orgasm in the ideal case (DeLamater & Hyde, 2004; Morris, 1977). This script is

generally followed both within a single sexual encounter and across a series of dates with only occasional variation.

Saying “no” to sex in a long-term relationship is often difficult because partners do not want to hurt one another’s feelings, but everyone has the right to refuse sex no matter how close the relationship. It is important for long-term partners to say “no” in a tender and supportive manner with clear verbal communication. Research has shown that most refusals are done verbally and that the best refusals maintain both the relationship and the partner’s face (Cupach & Metts, 1991). For example, telling your partner that you are “really tired” or “not feeling well” is better than saying that you are not feeling much sexual desire for her or him at the moment. When refusals are accompanied by assurances of future activity (“We’ll have more time for each other this weekend”), they are also accepted more gracefully.

Pillow Talk

Many studies have examined people’s communication before sex including seduction, hitting on a person, flirting, come-ons, propositions, pressure, booty calls, requests, and of course, turn-downs, turn-offs, rejection messages, declines, and refusals. But until recently few have looked at communication following sex.

This gap has been filled by researchers doing studies on pillow talk and postcoital behavior. Pillow talk is the tranquil, intimate conversation that takes place after sexual intercourse or sexual climax (Denes, 2013). Pillow talk is often accompanied by relaxation, physical and psychological closeness, cuddling, and pleasant conversation, including expressions of affection and liking (Denes, 2012). Pillow talk often involves disclosure. Research shows that partners who orgasmed engaged in increased self-disclosure, particularly positive disclosure, and found greater benefits from disclosing than partners who did not experience orgasm (Denes & Afifi, 2014).

Pillow talk and nonverbal interaction following sex may have a chemical basis in the release of oxytocin and serotonin. Oxytocin is a chemical released during affectionate communication (see [Chapter 7](#)), by women during breast feeding, and by both men and women following orgasm. The presence of oxytocin (sometimes known as the “love hormone”) along with individuals’ biological ability to process oxytocin, is related to how much disclosure occurs following sexual intercourse (Denes, 2015); more oxytocin, more disclosure. A different sort of relationship has been found between testosterone and post-sex communication (Denes, Afifi, & Granger, 2016). Higher testosterone levels were associated with disclosure being perceived as less beneficial and riskier, and the disclosures that did occur were less intentional and less positive. Moreover, higher levels of testosterone were associated with more negative thoughts and more negative disclosure for those people who did not orgasm, indicating that this group does not obtain as many benefits of post-sex communication. It may be that people with lower levels of testosterone are more nurturing and are more likely to employ pillow talk as a way to bond and connect with their partner.

Interestingly, alcohol consumption was negatively associated with pillow talk and deep disclosure; in addition, the disclosure was perceived as less beneficial (Denes & Afifi, 2014). There may also be a difference in romantic relationship sex as opposed to hookups or one-night stands. For long-term partners, the postcoital

period is one of connection and intimacy, but for short-term sexual interactions, such as one-night stands or hookups, it may be about regrets, disentanglement, or even dealing with embarrassment. Post-coital regrets are more common for alcohol-induced than marijuana-induced sexual encounters (Palamar, Acosta, Ompad, & Friedman, 2016). Of course, sometimes post-coital conversations are about pregnancy, disease, cheating, and other negative topics.

Pillow talk is often accompanied by affectionate nonverbal interaction following sex like cuddling, kissing, and sweet tones of voice. Cuddling, kissing, and caressing are affectionate nonverbal behaviors that can occur after sex and result in greater sexual and relational satisfaction (Muise, Glang, & Impett, 2014). Pillow talk sometimes takes the form of baby talk and couples that employ baby talk have greater intimacy and attachment to one another (Bombar & Littig, 1996). The sweet tones of voice used by lovers may be reminiscent of the intimacy of infancy. Both men and women engage in kissing before and after sex, but men are more likely to initiate kissing before sex and women after sex (Hughes & Kruger, 2010). Sex makes some people sleepy and although this is partly a physical response, your partner may feel disrespected if you snooze off and post-sexual behavior doesn't include cuddling, caressing, and pillow talk.

Sexual Coercion and Harassment

Most people associate sex with pleasure, intimacy, relational closeness, and desire. However, sex has its dark side as well. Negative aspects of sex include sexual dysfunction, sexual abuse, rape, sexual coercion, and sexual harassment. In this section, we focus on coercion and harassment because communication is at the heart of these types of problematic interaction.

Sexual Coercion

Sexual coercion occurs when an individual pressures or forces another to engage in sexual activity or generally unacceptable practices, with physical force the most unacceptable (Struckman-Johnson & Struckman-Johnson, 1991). Verbal insistence is the most common and least aversive method of coercion (Murnan, Perot, & Byrne, 1989). Women generally find sexual coercion to be less acceptable than men (Christopher, Owens, & Strecker, 1993; Struckman-Johnson & Struckman-Johnson, 1991). Coercive strategies are generally unsuccessful in gaining sexual compliance (Christopher & Frandsen, 1990).

Sexual coercion is far too common. News headlines about sexual coercion and rape on college campuses are an almost daily occurrence; these news stories and books have created a national outcry. Research has shown that in the majority of sexually coercive situations, a man is the perpetrator. Over 50% of college women report having been victims of sexual coercion (Byers, 1996), and over 95% of all women report having engaged in some form of unwanted sexual activity (Muehlenhard & Cook, 1988). Other studies have shown that over 20% of college women report having been forced to engage in sexual intercourse, and 35% to 46% of women report having unwanted sex as a result of sexual persuasion or coercion, typically from a partner the woman knew fairly well (Byers, 1996; Muehlenhard & Cook, 1988; Murnan et al., 1989; O'Sullivan & Allgeier, 1998). If unwanted sexual penetration in any form is used as a standard, the most recent data suggest about 20% of college women have been raped (Muehlenhard, Peterson, Humphreys, & Jozkowski, 2016). Women report experiencing sexual coercion on about 7% of all dates (Byers & Lewis, 1988) and 50% of college women reported that they had engaged in at least one unwanted sexual activity. Sometimes women have unwanted sex to please their partners; other times they are pressured or forced to have sex. Worst of all, almost two thirds of sexual assaults occur with regular relational partners (Christopher & Kissler, 2004). Recent research on 30,000 college students shows that gay men and bisexual men and women are the most common targets of sexual coercion and victimization (Johnson et al., 2016).

As Charlene Muehlenhard, a leading sex researcher in the Psychology Department and Women, Gender, and Sexuality Studies Department at the University of Kansas, and her colleagues have pointed out, the issue of sexual consent on campus is filled with complexities (Muehlenhard, Peterson, Humphreys, & Jozkowski, 2016). Decisions about how to communicate consent/nonconsent are often sequential and contingent. While nonconsent is usually communicated verbally, nonconsent often begins with less-explicit nonverbal cues (Muehlenhard et al., 2016). Nonverbal cues, such as turning the lights back on or moving someone's hand, may be too subtle, but even verbal cues are often counterbalanced with confusing positive relational maintenance cues.

For many people, especially women, two goals may conflict: maintain the relationship but stop the sexual advance (Muehlenhard et al., 2016). Women sometimes fail to send sexual resistance messages because they fear the relational consequences of turning down their partner (Motley & Reeder, 1995). The reality is, men rarely disrupt or terminate a relationship because a woman resists sexual escalation. In fact, Motley and Reeder (1995) found that men rarely are hurt, offended, or angered when women use direct sexual resistance messages. Because women seldom are rejected in their attempts to sexually escalate a relationship, they are more likely to be hurt and upset if they are rejected. They project these feelings onto men, who rarely share their hurt and anger over being sexually rejected. Many men, on the other hand, have considerable experience with sexual rejection and have learned coping strategies to deal with rejection short of relational de-escalation or breakup.

Another source of confusion is that a majority of both men and women believe that not resisting is usually a consent cue (Muehlenhard et al., 2016). Yet one of the most common reactions of women to sexual advances or coercion is no response (Byers, 1996). The prevalence of a party culture on most campuses and alcohol can compound the situation since it may impair a woman's ability to resist and makes sexual coercion seem more acceptable to some men (Abbey, 2011; Muehlenhard et al., 2016).

In most situations in which men pursue sex and women refuse, men halt their sexual advances (Byers, 1996). About 15% of the time, however, the man does not believe the woman's refusal really means no (Byers & Wilson, 1985). Men often perceive that the woman's refusal is only token resistance (Muehlenhard & Cook, 1988). Research has shown that men often do not perceive indirect resistance messages on the part of women as real resistance (Motley & Reeder, 1995). Indeed, Motley and Reeder suggested that women need to be much more direct in communicating sexual resistance and that men should listen more carefully to understand women's resistance messages.

When token resistance is used, the situation is confusing and dangerous. Both men and women use token resistance, but contrary to the stereotype, men are more likely to use it than women (O'Sullivan & Allgeier, 1994). As noted previously, a sexual initiator should not ignore a request to stop. If, however, an initiator has learned that stop does not really mean stop, "real" requests to stop may be ignored, leading to problems ranging from relational disagreements to sexual assault. Thus, it is best to stop and ask for clarification if you think your partner might be engaging in token resistance. Unless your partner explicitly says "yes" and not "no," you should avoid further sexual activity. Clearly, men should never try to second-guess a woman's motivation for saying "no." As Andersen (2008) stated, when people misinterpret nonverbal cues or ignore explicit verbal cues in favor of nonverbal cues that erroneously appear positive, sexual harassment or date rape can follow. Therefore, "stop" always means stop, and "no" always means no.

In about 10% of sexually coercive situations, the woman is the aggressor and the man is the target. Among college students, about one third of men reported an episode of pressured or forced sex since the age of 16 (Byers, 1996; Struckman-Johnson & Struckman-Johnson, 1994), and in the vast majority of these cases, the perpetrator of coercion was a woman. O'Sullivan and Allgeier (1998) reported that over a 2-week period, 26% of college men engaged in an unwanted sexual act and almost 9% had unwanted sexual intercourse.

Struckman-Johnson (1988) found that 16% of the men in her sample reported an incident of forced sexual intercourse. Muehlenhard and Cook (1988) studied over 1,000 men and women in introductory college psychology courses and found that more men (62.7%) than women (46.3%) reported having unwanted sexual intercourse. Although men generally have less negative reactions to being the target of coerced sexual encounters than women, one fifth of the men in a study by Struckman-Johnson and Struckman-Johnson (1994) had a strong negative reaction to the experience.

Studies have shown that women are not very sensitive to male refusals to have sex. O'Sullivan and Byers (1993) found that when met with a refusal to have sex, 97% of women still tried to influence the man to have sex. Women are not used to being refused, and they find such refusals unpredictable, constraining, and uncomfortable (Metts et al., 1992). Men may have neither experience in nor well-developed scripts for saying "no," and believe it is unmanly to refuse sex (Metts et al., 1992). They also engage in unwanted intercourse due to peer pressure, inexperience, sex-role concerns, and popularity factors (Muehlenhard & Cook, 1988). Of course, both men and women often experience ambivalence about having sex, so some of these cases of unwanted sex probably represent situations where mixed feelings were present.

You should never assume that someone is using token resistance. "No" means no, and "stop" means stop.



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Sexual Harassment

Sexual harassment occurs when inappropriate sexual comments, behaviors, or requests create a hostile work or school environment or when a person feels pressure to have sex to avoid negative consequences. Harassment is too common in the workplace, among friends and acquaintances (Keyton, 1996). Although men sometimes

experience sexual harassment, research shows that women experience it far more. In fact, studies suggest that one out of every two working women was sexually harassed (Swan, 1997). A study by Hesson-McInnis and Fitzgerald (1997) of 4,385 women employed by the federal government found 1,792 reported they were sexually harassed at least once in the past 2 years. This problem was even worse for minority women; Hargrow (1997) found that over 80% of the working African American women she surveyed reported experiencing sexual harassment. Sexual harassment is a serious problem; it in turn negatively affects job satisfaction, health, and psychological well-being (Glomb et al., 1997).

Describing the behaviors that constitute sexual harassment is complicated. What some people see as harassment, others might see as sexy or innocent fun. Moreover, women sometimes perceive behaviors to be more sexually harassing than do men, especially if they have recently entered the workforce (Booth-Butterfield, 1989). In any case, research suggests that certain verbal and nonverbal behavior should be avoided. Dougherty, Turban, Olson, Dwyer, and Lapreze (1996) noted that some behaviors, such as making lewd comments or grabbing someone's breasts or buttocks, are blatantly harassing. Marks and Nelson (1993) found that potentially inappropriate touching by professors was seen as more harassing than inappropriate verbal comments. Less sexually oriented forms of touch, such as on the shoulder or around the waist, are not perceived to be as harassing as verbal comments. Dougherty and colleagues (1996) compared people's interpretations of potentially harassing situations involving touch behavior (putting an arm around a female coworker's shoulder) and verbal behavior (asking a female coworker how her love life was and if she'd had any exciting dates lately). They found that the verbal comment was perceived as more harassing than the touch.

More specifically, Lee and Guerrero (2001) compared types of touch to determine which were perceived as most harassing. They excluded blatantly harassing touches, such as grabbing breasts or buttocks or kissing someone on the mouth, and instead focused on more ambiguous forms of touch. Of the eight types of touch they studied, touching the face was perceived as most harassing, followed by an arm around the waist. Lee and Guerrero subsequently theorized that types of touch that invade people's personal space are particularly threatening. The face is an especially vulnerable part of the body, and letting someone touch it requires trust. Interestingly, not everyone saw these types of touch as harassing. In fact, while about one third of the participants "agreed strongly" that face touch was sexually harassing, another one third "disagreed strongly." This suggests that some forms of touch are seen as harassing by some people but not others, which leads to confusion and misunderstanding.

When people encounter sexual harassment, they can respond using passive, assertive, or retaliatory strategies. Passive responses, also referred to as *indirect strategies*, involve ignoring the harassment or appeasing the harasser. **Assertive responses** involve telling the harasser to stop the behavior, with statements such as "Please stop bothering me," "I'm not interested in you that way," "I'm seeing someone else so I'd appreciate it if you'd stop asking me out," and "Your behavior is inappropriate and unprofessional." Assertive responses also involve issuing warnings, such as threatening to talk to the harasser's supervisor. Finally, **retaliatory responses** involve punishing or getting revenge on the harasser, usually by harassing the person back, making derogatory comments about the harasser to others, or getting the harasser in trouble.

Unfortunately, there is not always an effective way of responding to sexual harassment. Swan (1997) found that people who viewed sexual harassment experiences as highly upsetting were most likely to use coping strategies. When people used assertive strategies, they reported feeling better about their jobs and themselves. By contrast, when people used passive or retaliatory strategies, they reported feeling even worse. Retaliatory responses diminished job satisfaction, and passive responses diminished job satisfaction and psychological well-being. However, some studies also have shown that assertive strategies can exacerbate the problem (Schneider, Swan, & Fitzgerald, 1997). Bingham and Burleson (1989) found that although sophisticated verbal messages were more effective at stopping sexual harassment than unsophisticated ones, neither type of message was very effective. Because sexual harassment often involves a power imbalance, it is a particularly difficult situation. If the victim uses passive strategies, the individual remains powerless, and the harassment is likely to continue. But if the victim uses direct strategies, the powerful person might resent being told how to act and retaliate by demoting the victim or making the work environment even more unpleasant. Even so, research suggests that assertive strategies are most effective. If these strategies do not work, the victim may need to talk with the harasser's supervisor.

Communication and Safe Sex

So far we have discussed how communication about sex can enrich a romantic relationship. We have also examined some highly problematic aspects of sexual interaction, including coercion and harassment. Another problematic issue is unsafe sex. The safest form of sex in relationships is no sex. Abstinence is the best way to avoid unwanted pregnancy, AIDS, and other STIs. But total abstinence from sex is unusual, unrealistic, precludes most romantic relationships, and fails to work with the high percentage of adolescents who are not virgins (Rasberry & Goodson, 2009). Thus, additional safe sex practices are imperative. Unfortunately, being in a close relationship inadvertently puts partners at risk since trust is higher and, as a result, safe sex is practiced less in the closest relationships (Noar, Zimmerman, & Atwood, 2004). Worse yet, information and communication about STIs are far less common than they should be; although many publications give excellent advice for safe sex and AIDS prevention (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, 1997; Larkin, 1998). STIs are epidemic in the United States; 65 million Americans have an incurable STI such as genital herpes or HIV (Noar et al., 2004). [Box 9.5](#) provides a list of likely familiar rules to help avoid AIDS and other STIs. (For more information about HIV/AIDS, contact your campus health service or county health department.)

Box 9.5 Highlights: General Rules of Safe Sex Practices

1. **Practice abstinence.** Although complete abstinence is unlikely for most adults, about 12% of the college-age population are virgins who have had no high-risk sexual activity (Sprecher & Regan, 1996). Abstinence is the most effective policy when it comes to preventing STIs.
2. **Practice secondary abstinence.** Secondary abstinence involves starting to abstain from sex after having previously been sexually active. Research shows that this practice is popular with more religious young people and those who believe that abstinence is normative. Unfortunately, conventional abstinence education appears to decrease the likelihood of secondary abstinence (Rasberry & Goodson, 2009).
3. **Avoid high-risk sex.** HIV and other STIs are spread by exchanging bodily fluids. Intercourse is particularly dangerous. One episode of unsafe sex with an HIV positive person puts you at risk for catching the virus. Multiple unsafe sex episodes put you at even greater risk (Hammer, Fisher, Fitzgerald, & Fisher, 1996).
4. **Use condoms.** During sexual intercourse, a new latex condom offers good protection from the transmission of HIV. Old condoms and “off brand” condoms offer poor protection because they may break or leak. Condoms made from animal membranes (skins) are porous and offer less protection against HIV transmission. Although condoms do not offer complete protection, when condoms are used properly, they are highly successful in preventing HIV/AIDS even with an infected partner (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, 1997; Noar et al., 2004).
5. **Get tested.** If you are uncertain whether you have been exposed to HIV, get tested. Only about 1% of those who are tested show the presence of HIV, so the test is likely to relieve you of concern that you have the virus. If you are HIV positive, you need to get treated immediately. With the proper treatment, many people who are HIV positive live many symptom-free years and even decades. Your campus health center or county department of health typically does HIV tests that are either anonymous or confidential. You can also use an HIV home test kit.
6. **Limit your partners.** Another good preventive technique is to limit yourself to a single partner who was previously a virgin, has been strictly monogamous, or has been tested for HIV since her or his last sexual encounter like Brittany and Chris did. Remember, when you have sex with your partner, you are exposing yourself to risk from every person who has had sex with your partner in the past. Having sex only in the context of a monogamous infection-free sexual relationship provides you with protection and may be the healthiest form of sexual activity (Noar et al., 2004).
7. **Really know your partners.** A partner you know, respect, and trust is the safest person with whom to have a sexual relationship, but this can be misleading. It is risky to have sex with a new acquaintance, with someone whose sexual history you do not know, or with a partner you do not trust. Research shows that people make flawed judgments about who is a safe partner. People erroneously believe that having sex with healthy looking, attractive people; friends; or people similar to themselves is safe (Noar et al., 2004); sometimes it is not. Research also shows that people find it difficult to discuss safe sex and condom use during a sexual encounter with a new acquaintance (Rosenthal, Gifford, & Moore, 1998). Again, people who fail to communicate about safe sex are literally risking their health.
8. **Avoid intoxication.** Research shows that binge drinkers engage in more sexual activity with a wider variety of partners (Mongeau & Johnson, 1995) than do heavy drug users, although drug use also increases risk of STIs. Studies also show that people are most likely to lapse in safe sex practices when under the influence of alcohol and drugs. Binging on alcohol or using drugs is a major predictor of failure to use condoms and of catching STIs (Hammer et al., 1996; Lindley, Barnett, Brandt, Hardin, & Burcin, 2008). Alcohol use, sex while intoxicated, and unsafe sex are prevalent on college campuses, especially with members of sororities and fraternities (Scott-Sheldon, Carey, & Carey, 2008).
9. **Be honest.** It is essential to report unsafe sex outside your relationship to your partner so that appropriate steps can be taken. Obviously, telling your partner about past sexual activity or recent infidelities can be uncomfortable and harm your relationship. But in the long run, it is far better to warn your partner of possible dangers than to save yourself from discomfort or conflict.

As some of the rules listed in [Box 9.5](#) suggest, communication is an essential ingredient in promoting safe sex. Unsafe sex can occur with any partner—even one you know well. It is therefore always best to be proactive about safe sex with every partner. This requires communicating with partners about past sexual experiences and talking about safe sex practices, such as those discussed in the following section. Unfortunately, many

people are complacent when they have sex with someone they know well (Hammer et al., 1996; Noar et al., 2004; Rosenthal et al., 1998). They believe that being well acquainted with someone means that they are free of STIs. Recent research suggests that 99% of one college sample were confident in their assessment that their partner did not have an STI despite research showing that over one third of college students have an STI (Afifi & Weiner, 2006). Brittany, in our chapter opener, made an intelligent decision: before she got sexually involved with Chris, she insisted they both get tested for STIs. They waited to have sex until they were both found free of STIs.

Many sexually active people believe that they can tell if a partner is lying to them about safe sex behaviors. In actuality, research has shown that people cannot tell when someone is lying about sexual behavior or HIV status (Swann, Silvera, & Proske, 1995). Particularly dangerous is the truth bias, whereby individuals tend to assume that people they like are telling them the truth (see [Chapter 13](#)). Trust is important in relationships, but is it worth your health to trust someone who could be wrong about her or his HIV status?

Another danger is people's lack of condom use, even though they know that condoms help prevent STIs. Using condoms consistently, meaning *every time* you have sexual intercourse, is the only effective way to prevent STIs during intercourse (Noar et al., 2004). Studies show that only about one third of couples use any form of contraception during intercourse (Willett et al., 2004). Many couples decline to use condoms because they limit spontaneity and reduce sensation (Hammer et al., 1996). Yet about one third of the males in Hammer and colleagues' study reported that sharing the act of putting on a condom can actually bring the couple closer and is arousing. Research suggests that when a woman verbally suggests use of a condom, romanticism, emotional closeness, expectation for sexual relations, and condom use are maximized (Alvarez & Garcia-Marques, 2011).

Logically people should use condoms to prevent STIs, but in real relationships, factors other than logic influence condom use. Managing identity, not wanting to seem promiscuous, not wanting to destroy a romantic moment, not liking the feel of condoms, and believing a partner is "safe" are factors that influence decision making regarding whether to use condoms (Afifi, 1999; Galligan & Terry, 1993). Knowledge of the risk reduction effects of condoms are a major motivator for people to use them, but women were less likely to use a condom when they feared it would destroy the romance of the moment (Galligan & Terry 1993). Afifi (1999) reported that when attachment to a partner is high and suggesting condom use will be perceived as a lack of trust, condom use decreased. Of course, suggesting condom use may not always be perceived negatively by one's partner; rather, it may be seen as a sign of caring and of responsibility.

These findings underscore the importance of communication; partners should have frank discussions about safe sex before becoming sexually involved. Almost any communication strategy increases the likelihood of condom use, but discussing pregnancy prevention or suggesting condom use "just to be safe" are the most effective strategies, because talking about AIDS can make people uncomfortable (Reel & Thompson, 1994). By contrast, discussing the sexual history of the partners, negotiating monogamy, and requesting that the partner use a condom can promote safe sex (Cline, Freeman, & Johnson, 1990). However, Cline et al. found that those who discuss safe sex are only a little more likely to engage in safe sex practices than are those who

do not. Therefore, it is crucial that partners do more than talk about safe sex practices: they must also take appropriate action to protect one another.

Summary and Application

Sex is a vital part of most romantic relationships. Partners who have similar sexual attitudes and high-quality sexual interaction are likely to be satisfied with their sex lives. Sexual satisfaction is associated with relational satisfaction, although it is important to remember that other factors, such as affection, love, and compatibility, are more important. Similarly, partners who are knowledgeable about sex are generally happier with their sex lives.

The research discussed in this chapter can help people like Taylor, Sarah, and Brittany in at least two ways. First, research on sexual attitudes can help them better understand their sexual selves. Second, research on sexual communication can help them improve how they talk about sex with their partner, both before and after engaging in sexual activity. In terms of sexual attitudes, Taylor has accepted and embraced her homosexuality. Sex is important in lesbian relationships, but nonverbal affection may be even more important to Taylor and Leslie. When Taylor hears homophobic comments and sees strange looks on the faces of her sorority sisters when she mentions Leslie, she has every right to be upset. But Taylor might be consoled by recognizing that people have different attitudes and preferences regarding sex whether they are homosexual or heterosexual. For instance, Sarah sometimes struggles with derogatory comments that people direct at her because she is a virgin.

For her part, Sarah should be comforted by the fact that about 12% of college students (and 13% of women college students) are virgins and that people who remain virgins because of strong moral beliefs and values are usually happy and proud of their virginity. Indeed, if Sarah gave up her virginity for the sake of pleasing her boyfriend or conforming to social norms, she might very well regret her decision. Research suggests that Sarah should refuse sexual advances in a direct manner, using clear verbal communication. Her boyfriend might use a wide variety of strategies to try to convince her to have sex, including pressure, manipulation, or antisocial behaviors, but research suggests that these strategies are likely to backfire or result in less relational satisfaction, so they should be avoided. Research also suggests that Sarah's boyfriend will accept her decision.

Because she refuses to have sex, Sarah is in the position of being the sexual gatekeeper in her relationship with her boyfriend. Even in relationships that turn sexual, women tend to be in the gatekeeping position at the beginning of the relationship, with men cast in the role of sexual initiator. Socially accepted scripts for sexual communication are typically followed in the early stages of relationships. However, as the relationship develops, women usually feel freer to initiate sex. Unique, individual sexual scripts replace socially normative scripts in developed relationships.

Finally, communication plays an important role in promoting sexual satisfaction. Couples who tell each other their sexual preferences and communicate their needs, desires, and aversions are much more likely to be happier with their sex life, as are those who engage in cuddling and self-disclosure following sex.

Communication is also critical for promoting safe sex and avoiding STIs or an unplanned pregnancy, as Brittany's communication with her boyfriend exemplifies. Although Brittany does not talk about her sex life with her parents, she learned how to be sexually responsible from them. Parents should talk to their children

about sex in a supportive, nondefensive manner rather than issuing warnings. Partners like Brittany and Chris should also talk to each other openly and honestly about their past sexual experiences and the need to practice safe sex. However, it is important to remember that safe sex *talk* is not enough; safe sex *behaviors* promote healthy lives.

Key Terms

antisocial acts, as a sexual initiation strategy (p. 245)
assertive responses (p. 251)
attention stage (p. 240)
courtship readiness stage (p. 241)
delayed-involvement couples (p. 242)
expressions of emotional and physical closeness, as a sexual initiation strategy (p. 245)
friends with benefits (p. 230)
gradual-involvement couples (p. 242)
hinting and indirect strategies, as a sexual initiation strategy (p. 245)
hook-ups (p. 229)
invitations and sexual arousal stage (p. 241)
logic and reasoning, as a sexual initiation strategy (p. 245)
low-involvement couples (p. 242)
physical flirting style (p. 240)
pillow talk (p. 239)
playful flirting style (p. 240)
polite flirting style (p. 240)
positioning stage (p. 241)
pressure and manipulation, as a sexual initiation strategy (p. 245)
procreational orientation (p. 236)
quasi-courtship (p. 242)
rapid-involvement couples (p. 242)
recreational orientation (p. 236)
relational orientation (p. 236)
resolution stage (p. 242)
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scripts (p. 245)
serial monogamy (p. 236)
sexual scripts (p. 237)
sincere flirting style (p. 240)
traditional flirting style, (p. 240)

Discussion Questions

1. In this chapter, we presented data suggesting that most couples wait until some emotional intimacy or commitment has developed before engaging in sex. We also reported a study indicating that around 10% to 15% of college students are virgins. Based on the conversations you have had with friends, do you think these numbers hold true for your school? Why might these estimates differ depending on the group of people responding?
2. Based on what you learned in this chapter, what strategies would you use to protect yourself from sexual coercion or harassment? Why do you think people misinterpret supposed sexual cues so often?
3. Why do you think people practice unsafe sex even though they know the risks involved? What communication strategies might partners use to ensure that they engage in safe sex?